the past few weeks other than the expected seasonal variation," a report from the MoHFW after the meeting noted.

But unwilling to take any chances, India is ramping up the number of laboratories testing hMPV cases, and the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) will be monitoring trends of hMPV for the entire year. "At CMRI Kolkata," Dr Dhar reveals, "about 10-15 per cent of the total patients admitted to the ICU have metapneumovirus infection. I believe all hospitals, be it private or public, should have such preparedness and strategies in place to collaboratively fight the outbreak of the infection in India."

Karnataka has already issued an advisory exhorting people not to panic but be aware and mindful. It outlines the key characteristics of the virus, its symptoms and transmission and advocates important preventive measures. Meanwhile, the health authorities in Andhra Pradesh and Delhi have also urged local residents to observe caution as well as hygiene.

While the present outbreak seems to warrant nothing more than monitoring and caution at the moment, experts cannot emphasise enough the need to strengthen pandemic preparedness systems. This means healthcare infrastructure has to be in place to predict outbreaks, diagnose them and treat them on a large scale, if need be. India has seen a number of localised viral outbreaks—Mpox, Nipah, Chandipura—in the past year, a sign that more frequent human-animal interaction and changing climate conditions mean that another Covid-like pandemic is a possibility that the world will now never be able to discount. ■

Mamata's Border Outburst



SPEWING FIRE West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee

PTI

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

With heightened scrutiny of West Bengal's border security following arrests of alleged terror operatives over the past fortnight, the heated debate over "illegal migration" from Bangladesh has undergone a curious rhetorical inversion. Stung by the criticism, West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee and her nephew, Abhishek Banerjee, the Trinamool Congress (TMC) national general secretary, launched a scathing counter-attack on the Union government and the Border Security Force (BSF). Their charge: central complicity in allowing illegal immigration from Bangladesh through Bengal's porous borders to "destabilise the state".

After the West Bengal Special Task Force and the Assam Police arrested four suspected terrorists of the outlawed Ansarullah Bangla Team (ABT) from Murshidabad on December 18 and 30, the opposition BJP has been relentless in accusing the state government of failing to curb illegal immigration. Leader of the Opposition and BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari accused the TMC government of hindering the acquisition of land along the Bangladesh border by the BSF for building checkposts and other infrastructure. Union minister and Bengal BJP chief Sukanta Majumdar accused Mamata of making Bengal "a safe haven for terrorists".

THE BJP HAS ALLEGED THAT THE BSF IS NOT BEING GIVEN LAND TO BUILD BORDER CHECKPOSTS

Speaking at the state secretariat during the year's first administrative review meeting on January 2, Mamata hit back. "We have